Guide 6: Partnering with Local and Community Organizations



Training Overview

- Benefits of partnering with local and community organizations
- Assessing community needs & resources
- Examples of partnerships
- Resident Opportunity and Family Self-Sufficiency Programs
- Finding support for your resident council
- Planning to meet with potential partners
- Surveys
- Resources

Key Points



- Strong resident councils benefit from working with other organizations.
- Partnerships help residents respond to their community's needs, improve their housing, and quality of life.
- HUD encourages partnerships that help connect public housing residents with health care, education, and social services.
- Many community organizations value working with resident councils because doing so helps them fulfill their mission.

Benefits of Partnering



Partnerships help residents respond to their community's needs, and improve their housing and quality of life.



Partnerships help connect public housing residents with health care, education, social services, and local legal aid societies to offer services to their residents.



Bringing in services that residents need will help the resident council engage and build relationships with more residents.

Assess: What Needs Do Residents Have?

Your resident council should look for programs that will best meet the needs of the residents. Outreach to neighbors via posting flyers or door-knocking.

Some examples of programs that may interest families include:



Employment training programs



Credit and financial counseling



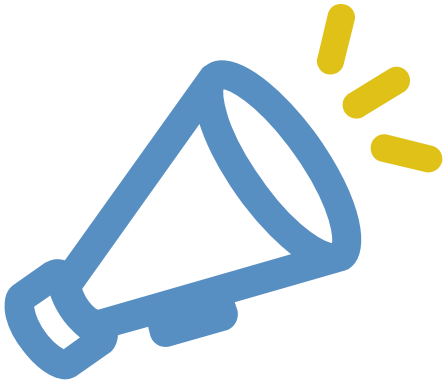
Free tax preparation for families



Programs for children such as homework support

Assess Residents Needs – Community Outreach

Consider:



- Door-to-door outreach at your property
- A dedicated email
- A dedicated phone number
- A lobby table to talk with residents about their needs and interests
- An idea box for residents to leave comments

Assess Residents Needs – Community Outreach



- **Brainstorming** — add this discussion topic at ***all*** resident council meetings
- **Survey** — paper or online. *Surveys work best when there are specific, concrete options.*
- Ask existing service providers or coordinators their opinions of what community needs are not being met *in addition* to your community.

For more information on service programs and coordinators, see Guide 7: Resident Training and Self-Sufficiency Programs.

Example: Assessing Needs Through Surveys



In Los Angeles County they noticed through surveys families were most interested in job placement opportunities rather than a job training program that might or might not lead to employment.

Assess Residents Needs — Key Questions

If you don't get responses with one method, try another!
No matter which method(s) you use, consider asking:

- What needs are unmet by the surrounding community?
- What services require travel?
- What services are not available at the times residents are free?
- What needs are the most urgent?
- What groups would these services support?
- Are there any groups in the community that are not being supported?
- What programs would residents want to participate in themselves?

Discussing Community Needs

"Is there a service, or community organization that you travel to but wish was closer?"



Prioritizing Ideas — Dot Voting

Dot Voting is a group decision-making process that starts with a brainstorm and then has the group narrow down the ideas to ones that have the most interest or agreement.

1. Give all the participants sticky notes.
2. Write one idea on each note.
3. They stick these ideas on the wall.
4. The facilitator groups the ideas.
5. Participants are given dot stickers to vote on the ideas that they like the best.



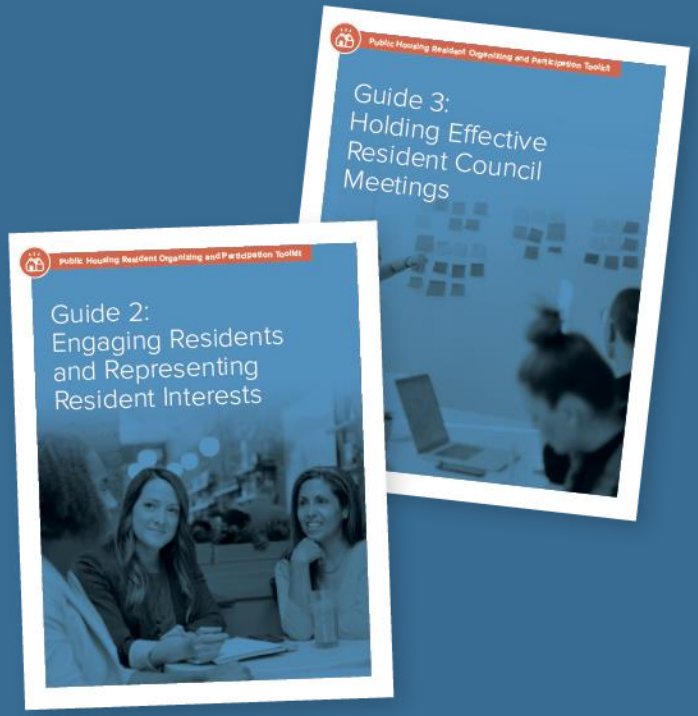
The group will be able to see visually which ideas have the most support.

Dot Voting Directions



"We are passing out 5 dot stickers to each person. Put one dot next to your five favorite ideas."

Additional Information



For more information on ***engaging residents***, see Guide 2: Engaging Residents and Representing Resident Interests.

For more information on ***group decision-making***, see Guide 3: Holding Effective Resident Council Meetings.

Knowledge Check



What strategies could your resident council use to determine community needs?

a. Community outreach

b. A survey

c. Ask service providers

d. Brainstorm at a meeting

e. All of the above

Knowledge Check



e. All of the above: To determine community needs your resident council can do outreach, a survey, ask service providers, and brainstorm at a meeting

Assess: Who Is Doing The Work?

After assessing needs and interests, look for which organizations exist that may be able to serve your community. Ask:

What organizations or people share the goals that our community has identified?

Where do residents in the community volunteer or work?

Which community organizations do residents go to for services?

Assess: What Other Organizations Are There?



Talk to the organizations you have identified.

- Tell them what needs you have identified.
- Ask them which services they do or could provide.
- Ask them what other organizations they know and recommend.

Do an internet search — For organizations that come up, ask:

- Are they already working with people in your community?
- Is there a relationship you could deepen?
- Do they do something your organization does not do?

Examples of Partnerships



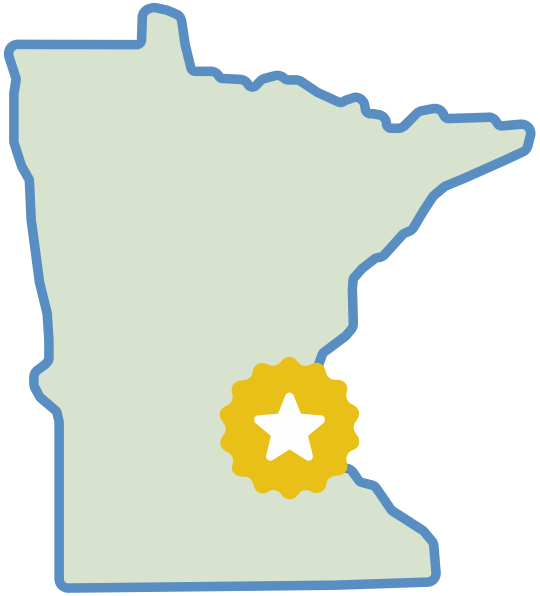
In Fall River, Massachusetts, public housing resident leaders benefit from support, training, and guidance provided by two statewide organizations, the Massachusetts Union of Public Housing Residents (Mass Union) and the Mel King Institute, as well as the National Alliance of Resident Services in Affordable and Assisted Housing (NAR-SAAH). These organizations provide residents with training, advocacy support, technical assistance, and opportunities to network with other resident leaders.

Examples of Partnerships



In Charleston, WV, the Orchard Manor Resident Council, part of the Charleston-Kanawha Housing Authority (CKHA) brought a mobile food pantry to their community. The pantry is housed in a small space in the community center. The resident council partnered with Feeding America Program and the Mountaineer Food Bank and provides food to over 50 people Monday, Wednesday, and Friday each week. When it's nice weather, the group additionally provides food from their community garden!

Examples of Partnerships



In St. Paul, Minnesota, public housing resident councils regularly partner with the Resident Services and Resident Initiatives departments of the St. Paul PHA to apply for grants the councils are eligible for as nonprofit organizations. For 8 years, they partnered with the St. Paul-Ramsey County Public Health Department to bring wellness initiatives, including physical activity, nutrition, and smoking cessation, to the residents.

Meet With The Housing Agency





Your housing agency may have community partnerships, connections to service providers, or programs that can be expanded to your community. They may want to partner to bring on a new program.

For more information, see Guide 4: Partnering and Advocacy with the Housing Agency.

Resident Opportunities and Self-Sufficiency (ROSS) and Family Self-Sufficiency (FSS) Programs

- Designed to assist public housing residents to make progress towards fully supporting their household.
- Provide service coordinators to properties.

Talk to the service coordinator about partnering, expanding programs, or bringing new programs.

- If the property does not have a coordinator, talk to the housing agency about bringing a service coordination program to the property.



For more information, see Guide 7: Resident Training and Self-Sufficiency Programs and the related training.

Partnership Example



In Los Angeles County ROSS service coordinators find that working with resident councils helps them ensure that residents can connect with outside services. Resident council meetings provide a way for service coordinators to introduce programs and organizations to residents. The service coordinators often have space on the agenda to speak or invite speakers from partner organizations.

Partnership Example



In Cincinnati, Ohio the Jurisdiction-Wide Resident Advisory Board is organized as a nonprofit organization with tax-exempt status. The group has a ROSS grant which funds three service coordinator positions that are filled by residents. The coordinators work to connect other residents to services.

Knowledge Check



The Resident Opportunities and Self-Sufficiency (ROSS) & Family Self Sufficiency (FSS) Programs are designed to assist residents of PHAs with:

a. Childcare

b. Making progress towards economic self-sufficiency

c. Immigration issues

d. Voter registration

Knowledge Check



b. Making progress towards economic self-sufficiency

Find Support For Your Resident Council

Support building resident council capacity, including:

- Assistance with HUD programs
- Engaging in advocacy
- Influencing decisions affecting your community
- Impacting community development

To impact community decisions and advocacy consider partnering with:

- Other resident councils
- Tenant rights and tenant organizing groups
- Legal aid organizations
- Educational institutions

Plan to Meet With Potential Partners

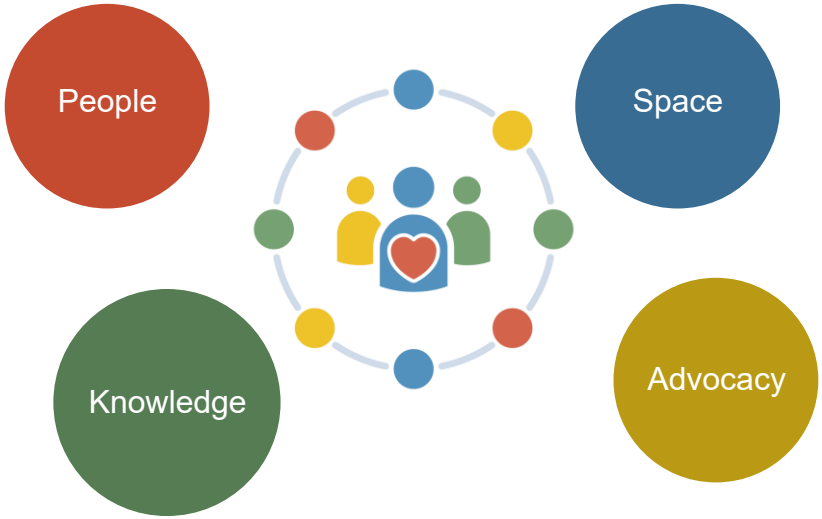
Before you meet with a potential partner organization, make a plan for the meeting. Consider:

- What are the goals and mission of the organization?
- Who are the organization's clients, members, or stakeholders and their goals?
- If they have clients, what are their clients' goals?
- Why would it be in the organization's self-interest to partner with you?
- How would the partnership help them reach one of their goals?
- Would any of their organization's priorities put them in conflict with the resident council?



What Resident Councils Bring To A Partnership

As a resident council you have a lot to offer to a potential partner:



Example: *A community organization may have the goal of helping people find employment. Your property may have a lot of people in need of this service (potential clients for them) and may be able to help provide the organization with free space to host workshops on writing a resume, or hold job fairs with employers.*

Example: Partnership Meeting



"We can offer you free space in our community center. You would get a lot more clients from our property if people didn't have to travel downtown for the service."

Knowledge Check



To impact community decisions and advocacy consider partnering with:

a. Other resident councils

b. Tenant rights and tenant organizing groups

c. Legal aid organizations

d. Educational institutions

e. All of the above

Knowledge Check



e. All of the above:

- Other resident councils
- Tenant rights and tenant organizing groups
- Legal aid organizations
- Educational institutions

Knowledge Check



What are some ways community organizations benefit from partnering with resident councils?

a. People

b. Space

c. Knowledge

d. Advocacy

e. All of the above

Knowledge Check



e. All of the above

- People
- Space
- Knowledge
- Advocacy

Surveys



- Customize any sample surveys
- Choose the most relevant questions and options
- Include specific options as well as space for additional ideas
- Offer electronic and paper options

Only ask for information if there is a specific reason. ***For example:*** *you may need to ask a general question about income to see if families will qualify for a program. Do not collect contact information on surveys with private information.*

This survey should be adapted to be specific to your community.

Survey for Residents of

_____

(name of property)

The _____ Resident Council is conducting a survey on our community's needs and interests!

We want to partner with organizations that will best serve our community. We need your help to determine which organizations to work with.

Which community-based or non-profit organizations already help you or your family?
For example, food banks, after-school programs, health clinics, etc. (Select all that apply)

- ☐ Boys and Girls Club
- ☐ Health clinic/center
- ☐ Community Organization: _____
- ☐ Other: _____

Surveys — Links



Guide 6: Partnering with Local and Community Organizations, Sample Survey, pages 11-12.

Community Needs Assessment Questionnaire from Survey Monkey:
https://www.surveymonkey.com/r/3RNQD5Y

The ROSS Notice of Funding Availability includes a needs assessment template related to employment:
https://www.hud.gov/program_offices/spm/gmomgmt/grantsinfo/fundingopps/fy2020_ross

Knowledge Check



True / False: A survey will work best if it is specific.

Knowledge Check



True:

The survey's purpose is to obtain important insights. Make sure each question adds value and relates directly to your goal.

Knowledge Check



True/ False: You should always include contact information on surveys so that you can follow up with people?

Knowledge Check



False:

Anonymous surveys are better — you receive more truthful responses. Do not include contact information on surveys. If you want to collect contact information for the resident council, collect it separately from the survey.

Animated video for Guide 6 (script)

Resources



Related Toolkit Resources:

- Guide 1: Organizing and Running Resident Councils
- Guide 4: Partnering and Advocacy with the Housing Authority
- Guide 5: Resident Advisory Boards and the Housing Authority Plan Process
- Guide 7: Resident Training and Self-Sufficiency Programs
- Case Study: Charleston-Kanawha, WV: Resident Councils Partner for Impact

Sample National Directories of Local Service Providers

211 — Is a nation-wide 3-digit number (and website) for information and connections to local services.

Boys and Girls Clubs — Uses a club experience to support young people to reach their full potential through. They currently have 290 clubs in public housing communities.

Find Help — Find Help connects people to food assistance, help paying bills, education and job training programs and other free or reduced cost programs by zip code.

HRSA Data Warehouse — This U.S. Department of Health & Human Services website includes tools to locate health programs funded by the Health Resources & Services Administration by your location.

Eldercare Locator — Created by the U.S. Administration on Aging, this searchable database connects people to services for older adults and their families. The service can be reached by phone at 1-800-677-1116.

The United Way — Has local chapters that work with many nonprofit agencies.

Resources



Community Toolbox: https://ctb.ku.edu/en/table-of-contents/participation/encouraging-involvement/increase-participation/main/

County Health Rankings guide on Building Your Partnerships Capacity for Change: https://www.countyhealthrankings.org/sites/default/files/media/document/Building%20Your%20 Partnership%27s%20Capacity%20for%20Change.pdf/

The Community Café: https://thecommunitycafe.org/our-work/

National Alliance of Resident Services in Affordable and Assisted Housing (NAR-SAAH) https://www.narsaah.today/

End of Training on Guide 6

This training is part of the **Public Housing Resident Organizing and Participation Toolkit.** The full toolkit includes topical guides, customizable resident council documents and forms, tools related to tenant participation funds, and case studies of resident organizations around the country. To see the full toolkit go to: https://www.hudexchange.info/programs/public-housing/resident-toolkit/

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